

It can be down for several days. Hmm, a convenience for customers that is not convenient at all if it does not work. But if it doesn't work, they end up with a late payment. Anyone smell something fishy? Recently, Pam had 48 hours left before her payment would be considered late. It was too late to mail a check to arrive on time. She kept waiting for the online payment option to work. She had the option to pay by phone, but they would charge her another fee of \$14.95, and frankly that's plain stupid. So she waited and hoped that the online payment service would magically get fixed. If not, she could mail and have a late fee, or she could pay by phone and have a "convenience" fee. This is modern day customer service?

It is probably true that most of us don't read the disclosure statements that come with our credit cards. The print is purposely too small and the language purposely confusing. Somewhere in the disclosure, it states that merely by using the card, you are indicating that you accept their terms. The real kicker is that the terms can change at any time for any reason, affecting current balances in the process. Occasionally you will get a mailing of a new disclosure statement all by itself with no explanation. That means your terms have changed.

They can do that. Whenever they want.

Nobody else is allowed to do that. The credit card companies are the only ones who can pull the switch-a-roo. Imagine this scene played out at the dinner of a married couple: The husband arrives home with a blonde on one arm, and a redhead on the other. The wife is appropriately stunned. The husband innocently says, "Honey, the terms of our agreement have changed. Didn't you read the fine print of that notice I left on your pillow?"

The credit card banks are a world unto themselves. The more cards you have, the more the banks can make. And the more opportunities they have to change your rates and terms. That is exactly why you will get ten offers from the same bank for cards with low limits, instead of an offer for one card with a higher limit. In my mind, that conjures up the image of the big, bad wolf in granny's head scarf, saying, "All the better to eat you up with."

I'm ready to switch fairy tales, but still want one with the big, bad wolf. Instead, in this version, we are the ones equipped to huff and puff and blow his house down.